

political space, the most famous inhabitant of the high-security ward of Etah district jail finds himself where he has always yearned to be. Smack bang in the spotlight.

It is a trajectory his father, brattish and brutish by turns, would almost be proud of. After all, it is his father whom he most admires as well. "I want to have his courage and strength of character. He stood for what he believed in, even if others did not agree with him," Varun said two days before leaving for Pilibhit to court arrest for his inflammatory comments. Who is the real Varun—now called Feroze only by those closest to him? Is he a victim, still no more than a helpless three-month-old who saw his father's rising star crashlanding in the Pitts S-2A flames? Is he a shrewd strategist, who sees a position as a fundamentalist rabble rouser being better than the obscurity of being forever the lesser Gandhi? Is he his mother's charming escort at socialite art dos, discussing Murakami and Mishima, with genteel artists and glitzy stars? Or is he a born again son of the soil who revels in the venomous language of barbarians?

His teachers at the British School in Delhi, where he studied between 1994 and 1996, after his initial years at the idyllic Rishi Valley in Andhra Pradesh, have interesting stories about him. Pamela Talwar, who taught him Hindi, recalls that as a 14-year-old he had watched a movie on India's first home minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and wanted to discuss it in class. When she discouraged him, he argued, asking why not? "He then went on to say that Jawaharlal Nehru used to get his clothes stitched and laundered in Paris, so how could he be a patriot. According to him, Patel was a bigger nationalist and should have been the first prime minister of the country," she recalls.

His academic credentials are questionable though, with his London School of Economics degree actually a University of London degree gained as an external student. He claims to have done his postgraduation in public policy from the School of Oriental and African Studies but it is something that he never completed. Varun has always had a keen interest in art and poetry, spurred no doubt by

family friend Prithvi Nandy. Between him and his mother, they have an art collection which can put any self-respecting gallery to shame, boasting of all the big names in Indian contemporary art. He dedicated his book of poetry *The Otherness of Self* to his mother in 2000, "for showing me that integrity is never a burden". But the collection also revealed his loneliness and confusion. As he writes in the forlorn *Alone: Sometimes I wished I lived alone/and no one came by/It would be nice to breathe alone/All my thoughts in solitude/and then it seems like being all alone/is like being in a crowd/my thoughts trapped in confusion/Like a kite caught in the sky/Imagine being caught in the sky.*

Varun grew up in an all-woman household, comprising three headstrong and willful women, mother Maneka, whose ambitious Rashtriya Sanjay Manch came to naught after Indira Gandhi's death; aunt Ambika Shukla who runs the NGO, People For Animals; and grandmother Amteshwar Anand, no stranger to controversy, having at various times been a target of Mohammed Yunus's scurrilous writings and the capital's cruel scandal-mongering? They could not have failed to remind him of his lost inheritance and his absent father. As he said to INDIA TODAY in 2004: "My father was my grandmother's chosen son. He passed away and my uncle inherited his political mantle. The whole nation knows that." And then a little later, "You think I have had it easy? You think my mother has had it easy?"

He is described by his chatterati friends as being "quiet, austere and thoughtful" though artist Anjolie Ela Menon who illustrated his book calls him a "spoilt brat" who did not even thank her for her work, which was free. When he was studying law and philosophy at Durham University in 1998-1999, he was a bit of a dandy-about-town. Living off a handsome allowance of £1,500 a month, which he ran out of in two weeks, Varun would frequent fashionable restaurants and nightclubs, using late hotelier Lalit Suri's Mayfair flat as Party Central. Hadrian Brezeniak, a 30-year-old software consultant was one of his closest friends then and describes him as being always generous with his money.

And now with his venom.

with Subhash Mishra

BHASKAR PAUL

VARUN WITH THE LATE
PRAMOD MAHAJAN



THE BJP WILL NOW PORTRAY
VARUN AS A VICTIM OF VENDETTA
IN MAYAWATI'S UTTAR PRADESH.